Coming Attractions

By Ted Tally, Jack Feldman and Bruce Sussman

(Lights rising slowly on LONNIE WAYNE BURKE. He is perhaps 25 and is holding a revolver. Nearby are his Four HOSTAGES… Their hands are tied; they are gagged.)

COP 1: **(Pg 278-279)** Give up, kid! You haven't got a chance.

LONNIE: *(shouts through a window)* Come in and get me, you scumbags! *(3 gun shots. He ducks)*

MANNY: *(Cut to Manny who narrates. He has a tape recorder slung over one shoulder by a strap. to the audience)* The first time I met Lonnie, he was just a scared punk with a two-dollar handgun.

LONNIE: *(shouts)* Hey! Send a reporter in here! I got a list of demands.

MANNY: He was trying to knock over a laundromat when the owner tripped an alarm. Lonnie ended up with four hostages, and a year's supply of clean socks.

LONNIE: *(shouts)* I'll blow [them] away, I swear to God. Now gimme a reporter.

MANNY: *(enters scene)* Hey! I'll talk to him.

COP 2: Are you a reporter?

MANNY: *(evasively)* I got a tape recorder.

COP 2: Well, get in there and see what he wants. But don't *try* to be a hero.

INTRODUCTION

Small-time crook Lonnie Wayne Burke is a born loser when it comes to crime. But with the help of streetwise theatre agent Manny Alter, he becomes the next media sensation following in the footsteps of . . . Charles Manson, David Berkowitz and Ted Bundy. This selection looks at our celebrity-obsessed society and the lengths to which some will go for fame and fortune.

Coming Attractions by Ted Tally, Jack Feldman and Bruce Sussman

LONNIE: **(Pg 279-282)** Hold it right there. *(Manny freezes)* Get your hands up. Up! *(Manny raises his hands)* What's in the box?

MANNY: Tape recorder. See for yourself. *(Lonnie looks at the case, then steps back.)* You mentioned a list of demands?

LONNIE: Yeah, that's right. Turn that thing on. *(Manny pushes a button on the recorder, holds*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

out the mic) Okay. This is the guy with the gun. I got four hostages and I'm gonna waste 'em if I don't get [what] I ask for. I want a camera crew in here. I want the story of my life to be shown on *Sixty Minutes.* Over and out! *(to Manny)* What network are you from?

MANNY: Network? You gotta be kidding. For four lousy hostages? There's a woman barricaded in the shoe department at Bloomingdale's, and she's got a hundred and fifty. Forget it, kid. For four lousy hostages, no reporter's gonna cross the street. *(Lonnie looks dejected)* My name's Manny Alter -- I'm a theatrical agent!

LONNIE: You mean like -- actors? That kinda agent?

MANNY: Actors, magicians, dog acts. I was walking by - got curious. I went in the five-and-dime and stole this tape recorder -- thought you and me might have a little chat. *(Lonnie edges to "window," peeks out)* There's no reporters out there, kid. Not a single one.

LONNIE: *(miserable)* I'm a failure. I can't even make the six o'clock news. What's **WRONG** with me?

MANNY: You're vicious, but you got no vision. Nowadays, everybody's into crime. That makes it tough on a kid just starting out. You need a gimmick. See this? *(holds up left hand)* This is crime. And this is show biz. *(holds up right hand)* Now watch closely. *(claps)* That's *money,* kid. Get the picture?

LONNIE: I can't get in show biz. I got no talent.

MANNY: Don't ever say that again. You got a special gift. How many guys can put a gun up to somebody's head and blow their brains out?

LONNIE: Millions.

MANNY: Sure . . . But how many know how to ***market*** that talent?

LONNIE: You really think I could be a star?

MANNY: Kid, I know it! One thing I got, it's a great eye for potential. *(offers his hand)*

LONNIE: Okay, it's a deal! *(shakes his hand.)* But, what do I do now? *(indicates the hostages)*

MANNY: Ever been arrested before?

LONNIE: Plenty of times.

MANNY: You'll be back on the streets in 24 hours. *(yells to police outside)* He's coming out!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Don't shoot! *(to audience as Lonnie exits with his hands up)* Tell you the truth, I had doubts. I mean, he wasn't exactly another Manson or a Berkowitz. He lacked your true weirdness factor, if you know what I mean. But I figured with training and a little luck, we could ***simulate*** some craziness.

********* SCENE ********

LONNIE: (Pg 282-284) *(enters wearing a child's Halloween costume. A skeleton with a skull mask. He carries a "trick or treat" bag)* I feel ridiculous.

MANNY: Put your mask down. Flap your arms. Do something freaky. *(Lonnie obeys, with obvious disinterest)* Oh, is that ever scary! Now, I'm the guy in the house. C'mon, c'mon, I'm the guy. You ring the doorbell.

LONNIE: Ding dong!

MANNY: I come to the door. It's pitch black outside, and nobody's there! Ooooh, I got chills already! Then suddenly you jump out, and you say . . .

LONNIE: Trick or treat, you bourgeois pig.

MANNY: You gotta say it like you mean it. Say it scary.

LONNIE: Trick or treat; you bourgeois pig!

MANNY: *(in character)* "Oh my God, it's him! It's that hot new psychopath!" And you take your gun out of your bag and blast me, right between the eyes! *(Lonnie takes gun out of "trick or treat" bag and pretends to fire several rounds)* Big headlines all over the place! *(pause)* What's the matter? I thought we agreed on this.

LONNIE: ***You*** agreed. How do you expect me to murder people when I feel ridiculous? Why can't I just march up to the door and blast 'em?

MANNY: Because that's not gonna sell any newspapers.

LONNIE: Well, I don't like it. It ain't my style of crime.

MANNY: Crime shmime. I'm talking about ***journalism***. *(Lonnie is unconvinced)* Look, just wear the suit for the first three or four murders. That's all I'm asking. . .

LONNIE: That's just publicity. How much you think some editor's gonna pay to put my face on his cover? Hell with publicity, Manny! When do I start getting some bucks?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MANNY: You want bucks? For starters let's talk non-fiction book rights. *The True Story of Mad Dog Lonnie!* Still not enough? Let's talk film sale! And kids' toys, for Chrissake. Little plastic psychopath and victim dolls! And your face on everything -- tee shirts, posters, candy bars! **(Pg 286)** *(to audience)* After that, things happened quickly.

NEWSMAN: **(Pg 285)** [This just in] Metropolitan police denied any link between yesterday's brutal midtown slaying and an identical murder last week in the suburbs. In each case, eyewitnesses report the killer wore a child's skeleton costume and shouted political slogans.

TV REPORTER: **(Pg 286)** *(News theme music)* Newsflash! The Halloween Killer struck again, claiming his fourth, fifth, and sixth victims.

CHIEF BRADDOCK: We're looking for a man between 20 and 45 years of age, between four-foot-eight and six-foot-five, and weighing 135 to 250 pounds. If anybody should see such a man, contact this department immediately!

MANNY: **(Pg 287)** *(to audience)* The kid was sensational beyond my wildest dreams.

LONNIE: **(Pg 289)** I feel terrific, Manny. It's like I'm in the movies.

MANNY: **(Pg 290)** Keep it up and you soon will be. We couldn't buy the kinda publicity you're getting. **(Pg 291)** *(to audience)* Things were going so great that I began to worry. It seemed like every fruitcake in the country was trying to get a piece of the action.

TV NEWSMAN: **(Pg 292)** *(news theme music)* With me in our studio is a man who claims to be the Halloween Killer. Mister X, in the last two weeks, more than a hundred crackpots have turned themselves in, all claiming to be the Halloween Killer.

MISTER X: *(with a horrible French accent)* You want proof? *(points finger like a gun)* Bang! Bang! Trick or treat, you bourgeois pig!

MANNY: **(Pg 293)** *(to audience)* When I saw that, I knew I either turned Lonnie in, or the cops would never get him. So I gave Chief Braddock a call. *(on phone.)* Chief Braddock? Word is, the Halloween Killer is planning a big finale for Atlantic City Saturday night. Network TV -- the works. Be there and you got him.

*********** SCENE BREAK **********

We see Lonnie in a long gown, heels, a wig and a sash. He fixes his breasts, applies lipstick and prepares to go on-stage while Manny narrates the following

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MANNY: **(Pg 293-295)** *(to audience)* Call it irresponsible ... but I wanted the kid to be captured while a national spotlight was on him. So we disguised him as Miss Wyoming, and he got all the way through swimsuit without anybody noticing. *(Lonnie plays to the audience)*

(Music. Miss America has just been crowned. She carries a scepter and a bouquet of long-stemmed roses. MUSIC fades)

MISS AMERICA: *(In stilted poetic language)* What does America mean to me? A Lady with her torch on the shining sea / A Golden Bridge near a redwood tree . . . *(Lonnie takes gun from his sash and interrupts her acceptance speech)*

LONNIE: *(In a fake woman's pageant voice)* Trick or treat, you bourgeois pigs! *(Miss America screams and Lonnie fires his gun randomly)*

MANNY: *(to audience)* As luck would have it, some of Lonnie's shots hit the judges' table. *(pause)* And that's how they finally caught the dreaded Halloween Killer. . . The newspapers? Well, lemmee put it this way -- if the Second Coming had happened that same day, you woulda read about it on page ten. The courts? They turned the kid over to the headshrinker. And Lonnie was ready for 'em.

********** SCENE ********

(LONNIE speaks in his natural voice, not attempting to sound like a woman.)

SHRINK: **(Pg 296-297)** State capital?

LONNIE: Cheyenne.

SHRINK: State bird?

LONNIE: The meadow lark.

SHRINK: Principal industries?

LONNIE: Cattle, oil, and tourism. *(slips into his woman's persona as if on stage answering an interview question)* I'm especially proud to represent Wyoming in this year's pageant because my state was the first to ratify women's right to vote. *(curtsies -- in his own voice again)* This is part of my personality interview, isn't it?

SHRINK: *(pause)* Miss Wyoming, you're wearing a dress . . . And yet, before you came here, you used to dress up in a skeleton costume. Can you tell me why that was?

LONNIE: *(in his woman's persona)* That was the ceremonial garb of the Arapaho Ghost Dance, which is still held on reservations throughout our state. The Ghost Dance comes before a

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

large tribal hunt.

SHRINK: I see . . . So all those people that you shot . . .

LONNIE: *(in his own voice again)* You mean the buffalo?

SHRINK: *(to audience)* Lonnie Wayne Burke is convinced that he is Miss Wyoming -- a psychic trauma of profound dimensions. We must set him free to atone for our crimes against his psyche.

********* SCENE ********

MANNY: **(Pg 298)** Well, kid? Huh? Huh? Did I tell you?

LONNIE: It happened just like you promised. "Small crime, serve time. Big crime-gold mine!" *(both whoop with laughter)*

MANNY: I knew you'd never spend one second in the slammer, not after you passed your whacko test. Now all we gotta do is rake it in! **(Pg 300)** *(to audience)* I shoulda smelled trouble. You tell some two-bit punk that he's a star enough times, and pretty soon he'll start believing it. He worked day and night on his new club act. [And] when the time came for his TV debut, all I could do was cross my fingers and hope we were ready. . .

********* SCENE ********

SAMMY: *(intro music for talk show)* **(Pg 304-307)** AWRIGHT! I know you're all anxious to meet tonight's special guest. He's a Megadiscovery. Ladies and gentlemen, welcome my new best friend - the "Singin' Psychopath" – Mister. Lonnie. Wayne. Burke! *(gestures broadly)*

LONNIE: *(Singing)* JUST LOOK AT ME NOW! / I SET MY SIGHTS AND TOOK A SHOT AT DESTINY. / I KNEW THAT I COULD HIT THE MARK SOMEHOW. *(Spoken as music continues)* Me? I was always the shy kid, the one who got beat up at recess. But even then I had a dream! I'll never forget telling my favorite teacher about it. "Mrs. Von Zell" She smiled at me and said. "Lonnie Wayne, sweetheart . . . go see the school nurse." *(Singing)* WELL, WELL, MRS. VON ZELL, / JUST LOOK AT ME NOW! / JUST LOOK AT ME NOW! *(bows)*

SAMMY: Hey, Lonnie -- come over here and talk to me! I just gotta ask ya. You've gunned down 27 people, you've appeared on my show. Which was the bigger thrill?

LONNIE: Gotta be your show, Sam. No contest.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SAMMY: Now you're still under indictment, izzat right? Out on bail . . .

LONNIE: Out on bail, right.

SAMMY: Lonnie, now tell the truth. Somewhere down the line, you ***have*** to go on trial. What if - long shot, Lon, but stay with me here - WHAT IF you're actually convicted?

LONNIE: *(humbly)* Sammy, my lawyers tell me this thing could drag through the Appellate Courts for ten years. Until it's finally settled, I just can't let it affect how I perform. I owe that much to my fans.

SAMMY: Thank GOD for America, ladies and gentlemen, where everyone is entitled to all the justice he can afford. Ladies and Gentlemen- LONNIE WAYNE BURKE!

LONNIE: *(Singing as he exits)* JUST LOOK AT ME NOW! / I SET MY SIGHTS AND TOOK A SHOT AT DESTINY. / I KNEW THAT I COULD HIT THE MARK SOMEHOW. / JUST LOOK AT ME NOW!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ted Tally, Jack Feldman and Bruce Sussman
Book: Plays from Playwrights Horizons, Pgs 273 - 326
ISBN: 978-0881450477
Publisher: Broadway Play Publishers
Date (Month/Year): May 1987

AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
NIETOC

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY